

CULTIVARS

- Genovese
- Everleaf

INTENSIVE SPACING

- 4 rows per bed, spaced every 12" (30 cm) on the row

FERTILIZATION

- Basil will stay a long time in the ground and therefore is amended with lots of compost, whether fresh or aged. The rule of thumb is to spread it ± 1 inch (2,5 cm) across the entire bed. When the conditions of biological activity are not optimal (e.g., in cold or poor soils), add extra amendments of organic fertilizers like alfalfa meal (2-0-2) and/or pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2).

IRRIGATION

Irrigation Type

- Drip tape (4 per bed) : under plastic mulch.

Irrigation Management

- Root depth: Medium (24"-40")
- General: Average water needs, except during warm weather when more water is required to prevent wilting. Regular moisture throughout the growing season helps to ensure a good crop.

IMPLANTATION

We plan for 3 basil planting in the season and intend to harvest the plants over 6 to 8 weeks. This ensures a continuous supply of new leaves to be harvested every week. Basil is usually planted inside a hoop house or tunnel in order to prevent mildew diseases and extend the growing period.

STARTING SEEDS

4 weeks before transplantation date, sow 1 seed per cells in 128 plug flats. Seeds should be about 1/4" (5mm) deep in the cell.

- Place trays on heating mats and maintain soil temperature at 70 °F (21 °C) until emergence. At that time, the potting-mix must be kept moist at all times.
- After emergence, the ambient temperature in the nursery can be kept around 75 °F (24 °C) during the day and 65 °F (18 °C) at night.
- Transplants are ready to go in the fields when seedlings have 3-4 sets of leaves.
- 4 days before transplanting, harden off plants by exposing them to outside temperatures and reducing water.

EQUIPMENT

- Rotary harrow
- Broadfork
- 30" bed prep rake
- Popping tray
- Landscape fabric, staples, drip tape and fittings.

TRANSPLANT ITINERARY

- Pass through beds with the broadfork.
- Remove large debris from the bed if needed (use a flail mower or rake).
- Apply compost and/or amendments across the bed and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 2.5" (6 cm). Since the bed is covered with landscape fabric, it doesn't need to be cleaned up with another pass of the rake.
- Set out drip tapes, 4 lines per bed and start the system. Fix any leaks you may find at that point.

- Lay down landscape fabric and secure it with landscape staples each second step (5' or 1.5 m). Ensure that the soil cover is installed very tightly.
- Use the popping tray to facilitate extraction and transplant the basil seedlings. Do not bury the plug (the top should be even with the soil level) and make sure to place them in the center of each hole. 1 person/100'bed is a good ratio for an efficient workflow.
- Water the bed thoroughly the first time, keeping the soil moist for the first week after the transplant.

WEEDING

- No weeding required

PLANT PROTECTION

- At an early stage, aphids can infest the crop. If traced, spray plants with insecticidal soap spray. Introduce ladybugs one day later.
- If spraying soap or any other bio-pesticide, make sure to heavily rinse off any residue before harvesting. The smell and odour of the basil need to be left intact.
- After 4 or 5 weeks of harvesting, basil plants might lack nutrients and start to yellow. If any sign of this appears, weakly spray the plants with a well balanced organic fertilizer. Make sure NOT to use any sea products that could pass on the taste and smell unto the basil.

HARVEST

- Basil is a plant that bifurcates and splits into 2 every time you cut it. For a continuous supply, we harvest only the heads by pruning the plant on a weakly basis.
- Harvest begins when the plant reaches about 6 inches (15 cm) height and has 3 nodes.
- In a standing up and bending over position, clip off with your fingers each new head right above the branch off point. Use both hands to maximize efficiency and carefully deposit the heads into a clean harvest container.
- Leaves are easily bruised when picking, so handle carefully.

- Always cut as close as possible to the top of the leaf node. If you leave more than 1 inch (2.5 cm) above the leaf node, the plant will divert nutrients to this stub and away from smaller shoots that need them. This can restrict the overall growth of the plant.
- Harvest once or twice a week to prevent your plant from flowering. Once basil plant flowers, it will not produce any more leaves. Trim away any buds you see on your plant before they have the chance to blossom.
- To encourage vegetative growth and help the plant photosynthesize to its full potential, leave side leaves and only harvest new heads.
- Basil can be harvested at any time but should be dry when doing so. Water on the leaves might cause them to turn if turn black in storage.
- 1 person should clip ± 300 heads per hour.

CONDITIONING

- Basil is never washed and to avoid damage, it is harvested in the same box it is distributed in.
- If pre-packing or when delivering to restaurants, basil is packed in plastic bags filled with air. To prevent condensation in the bags, avoid varying temperatures.

STORING

- Basil is stored at room temperature ± 45 °F (7 °C) and should not be stored for longer than 2 days before being sold.
- Humidity should be kept high (95-100%). Use wet towels place into the storage box if needs be.
- Do not store at a temperature less than 50 °F (7 °C), otherwise, the leaves might turn brown.